However, one overlooked dimension of IOs' power is their relationship with domestic publics. While IOs often operate out of the public eye, their legitimacy hinges on perceptions of their responsiveness and value among ordinary citizens (Dellmuth 2018; Dellmuth and Tallberg 2023). Critiques of a "democratic deficit" argue that IOs are detached from the will of the people (Dahl 1999), but we build on existing work on IO legitimacy and instead contend that these institutions actively seek public buy-in, just as populist leaders often mobilize public opposition to IOs. Such institutions do so because they recognize that cultivating public support can indirectly influence state leaders, incentivizing greater engagement with global governance.

In sum, the prevailing narrative in much of the existing literature assumes that IOs are passive actors, mechanically reacting to state actions and operating within limited bounds. We challenge this assumption. IOs wield extensive agency and strategically deploy their resources to build positive relationships with member states, partner organizations, and even domestic publics. While their tools differ from those of states, IOs employ them with a similar goal: to maintain cooperation and fulfill their mandates despite opposition.

Understanding IOs as proactive, resourceful players in the international system re-frames common perspectives on global governance. Far from being mere instruments of state power, these institutions actively shape the dynamics of interstate cooperation, demonstrating resilience and adaptability in the face of populist challenges.

1.4.1 Key Players in the Fight for IOs

This book grapples with urgent questions: What tools do international organizations have at their disposal with which to assert authority, attract support, and rein in opposition from populist member states? How do their actions shape the broader landscape of global governance? To address these questions, we delve into the inner workings of IOs, exploring the motivations and actions of the key players within them. Four main groups shape IO behavior: IO staff and management, nonpopulist member states, populist actors, and domestic publics.